

Episode 35: Once Upon a Time... (26) *Saint Seiya* Part 13 – About the Final Episode of "*Saint Seiya Hades Twelve Temples Arc*"

The other day my ordered *Ratatouille* DVD arrived, so I immediately watched it with my wife on my home 37-inch "Kameyama Model."

3DCG animated movies really are great to watch in this environment too. Man, it was incredibly beautiful and amazing. Scenes with massive groups of mice swarming around - that was really something... (laughs).

This *Ratatouille* is my top anime of the year. The screen is wonderful, and above all, not one truly bad person appears. That's crucial. Nobody gets killed either. Even that critic Ego and the chef who was causing trouble ended up happy eating ratatouille at the end. I want to watch movies like this repeatedly.

In the final epilogue scene, my wife watching with me said: "That critic got a bit fatter, didn't he?"

During the story, protagonist Linguini tells Ego at their first meeting, "You like food but you're thin?" Receiving that, the epilogue probably made not just his personality but also his visuals slightly "plumper." Hmm, I see. I hadn't noticed that detail.

Movies and anime are definitely more interesting when watched with someone.

Oh, and delicious food too (laughs).

Well then.

The 13-episode "*Saint Seiya: Hades Twelve Temples Arc*" raised our staff's tension with each episode. Since Sky Perfect TV advanced broadcast preceded DVD release, completion and delivery had to match that advanced broadcast, making quite

tight schedules from series latter half, especially after Episode 9. Still, once things got exciting, there was no turning back. Every episode continued with deliveries stubbornly holding out until the very limit.

For "*Saint Seiya: Hades Twelve Temples Arc*", I handled all colour design, colour direction input, and finishing delivery final checking for Episode 1, but from Episode 2 onward Sakuma Yoshiko-san (佐久間ヨシ子) took charge. For episodes with gross production requested from **Dangan Pictures**, Suzuki Rumiko-san (鈴木るみ子), who handled colour direction for **Lifework** production episodes during the old TV series, participated in finishing inspection and special effects. She added another spoonful of essence to my colour design to expand story volume.

Colour design creates series or episode colour blueprints, but for each episode, colour direction and inspection are key.

For example, "The character colour direction from colour design for this scene is this brightness and colour, but let's strengthen shadows a bit more for this cut to add impression."

Some colour designers might say "Do everything exactly as I say!" but I think "As long as you maintain forms following basics, feel free to add where you can add." We design flow based on storyboards, but animation is living. Certainly storyboards show this kind of acting, but animation often changes things. Confirming actual animation each time is quite difficult.

Gradual addition/subtraction considering actual delivered animation flow, story/directorial intent, and screen brilliance is colour directors' speciality. When actually facing individual cut animation (key animation, in-between animation) and specifying appropriate "colours" for those images, plus controlling painted results, sense and experience matter most.

Then Sakuma-san, whom I trusted absolutely for colour direction, was taken away to colour design another work (cries), so I handled colour direction for the final 3 episodes again. Actually watching each completed episode, I honestly thought "I want to try colour direction for the end myself" (laughs). The story was reaching climax! My feelings intensified. And the final episode. I approached this final episode thinking it might truly be the "last *Saint Seiya*." The direction was Director Yamauchi. I fought with the intention of making it my culmination.

My final episode battle had the shortest schedule among all 13 episodes, but it was my most enjoyable battle. Truly a revenge match for *Legend of Crimson Youth* (laughs).

Director Yamauchi's sense of "timing (ma)." The distance between characters, breathing "timing," "timing" when layering action probably suits *Saint Seiya* best. Particularly this final Episode 13 had all those beautifully condensed, I think.

Meetings themselves always ended quickly. Discussing points of concern and important points, then "Please take care of it." This time was the same. From there was my battle.

This final Episode 13 was almost entirely battles inside Hades Castle (ハーデス城), but every scene was special colouring through light and shadow, scene by scene. I designed colour tones for each scene, but time was insufficient and backgrounds weren't coming up. Normally I should decide colours properly before sending to **doshi** (animation + finishing work), but I couldn't hold key animation at my place. The schedule was already insufficient. I wanted animation work to advance even slightly.

So I created colours with hunches like "probably like this!" and sent **doshi** orders. After backgrounds came up, I'd try matching - if OK as-is, lucky; if not, work hard to repaint. I colour-directed several scenes like this. Result: roughly perfect, but ah, I wanted to adjust various things anyway and ended up correcting most **TP** deliveries myself (bitter laugh).

Still, actually touching real animation is enjoyable. Checking key animation coming to me while getting excited. When wonderful key animation or in-between animation comes up, I get happy and tense simultaneously. "I must put good colours on this to make good screens!" Such feelings make me tense. As expected for the final episode, every cut had wonderful key animation, but what particularly made me tense and excited was the hand-to-hand combat action scene between **Rhadamanthys** and the four Saints including Seiya in **Pandora**'s room. Flowing animation. True animation brilliance!

Touching such key animation, getting excited, working hard but enjoyably while tension rises, I think "I want to keep working on this episode forever" (laughs).

But well, that's impossible (bitter laugh).

I sent all cels to photography and repeated rush checking. Then, the last. I gave OK to Hades Castle collapse cuts and finished all cuts. Amazingly, it was the morning before broadcast.

Thus "*Saint Seiya: Hades Twelve Temples Arc*" ended. Thanks to this work becoming a big DVD sales hit, afterwards theatrical "*Saint Seiya: Heaven Chapter Overture*" then "*Sanctuary Chapter*" and "*Elysion Chapter*" would be made, but well, those stories are for another time.

As an aside, Golden Week 2001, I went to Greece on my honeymoon. I spent time on Aegean Sea islands, and also visited a small island called Delos. This World Heritage island has temples, sculptures, and Roman-era ruins throughout. Just like the Sanctuary. Standing atop Mount Kynthos (キントス山) in the island's centre, looking down at the ruins spread below, I thought ah, maybe the scenery the Saints saw was like this too. A bit moving. Somehow I felt like bronze-coloured Saint Cloth boxes might be lying around there.

